

Female warrior
A female Viet Cong soldier poses with an RPG-7 rocket launcher in the Mekong Delta in 1968 *(above)*. Although figuring prominently as fighters in Viet Cong propaganda photos, women mostly served in support roles. The RPG-7, like the Degtyarev light machine-gun *(right)*, was a Soviet-manufactured weapon supplied to guerrillas via North Vietnam.



DEGTYAREV LIGHT MACHINE-GUN

The People's Liberation Armed Forces (PLAF), known to its American enemies as the Viet Cong, was a rural-based guerrilla army that fought against the US and the US-backed South Vietnamese government in the Vietnam War. Like the North Vietnamese Army (NVA) infantry who fought with them, the Viet Cong guerrillas were skilful and dedicated fighters. In combat they almost always suffered far heavier losses than their opponents, but they were sustained by comradeship and a clear sense of purpose.

The Viet Cong evolved from the communist-led Viet Minh guerrilla movement that fought against French colonial rule in Indochina. After the Viet Minh defeated the French in 1954, Vietnam was split, with the South coming under the control of the US-backed government of Ngo Dinh Diem and the North under communist rule. When the country was divided, tens of thousands of Viet Minh guerrillas from the South chose to relocate to the North; other former guerrillas resumed a peasant life in their southern villages.

Diem's government proved to be corrupt and brutal, soon alienating much of the population of South Vietnam. By 1957, small-scale guerrilla warfare had resumed in many rural areas. Sensing that the time was ripe to resume the struggle for a unified communist-ruled Vietnam, in 1959 the North Vietnamese government sent tens of thousands of former Viet Minh guerrillas back to the South as "cadres" with the intention of organizing a full-scale insurgency.

During their time in the north, these men had undergone rigorous training in the theory and practice of revolutionary warfare. They had learned that the political and military struggles were inseparable. After the long, tough journey to the South through trackless jungle, they made contact with villagers, slipping into the hamlets at night to talk to local people and win their support for a guerrilla campaign. The South Vietnamese peasants were prepared to listen to the cadres as people of their own kind, who spoke about issues that concerned them, such as excessive government taxes and unpopular local landowners. The National Liberation Front (NLF), set up in 1960 as the political arm of the guerrilla movement, backed up the propaganda efforts of the cadres with clandestine radio broadcasts, posters, and news sheets.

GUERRILLA ARMY

Wherever the cadres found support among the local population, they recruited guerrilla soldiers. The most promising young men were encouraged to leave their village and become full-time guerrillas; women were also taken to serve in support roles. There were plenty of willing volunteers, although various kinds of pressure were applied, and in some cases recruits were conscripted at gunpoint. The full-time guerrillas were subdivided into regional forces, which carried out low-level operations around the guerrillas' home area, and main force soldiers, who received thorough infantry training at bases in sparsely inhabited country and were readied for full-scale combat in large military formations. The peasants who remained in the villages were organized into a part-time guerrilla militia. They had only the most basic military training but could, for example, provide intelligence, set booby-traps for government patrols, and dig tunnels to serve as hiding places for guerrilla troops and their equipment.

By early 1965, the Viet Cong had extended its control over three-quarters of South Vietnam, achieved mostly through small-scale guerrilla activity. Viet Cong units raided villages, killing government-appointed village leaders and slaughtering local pro-government militia.